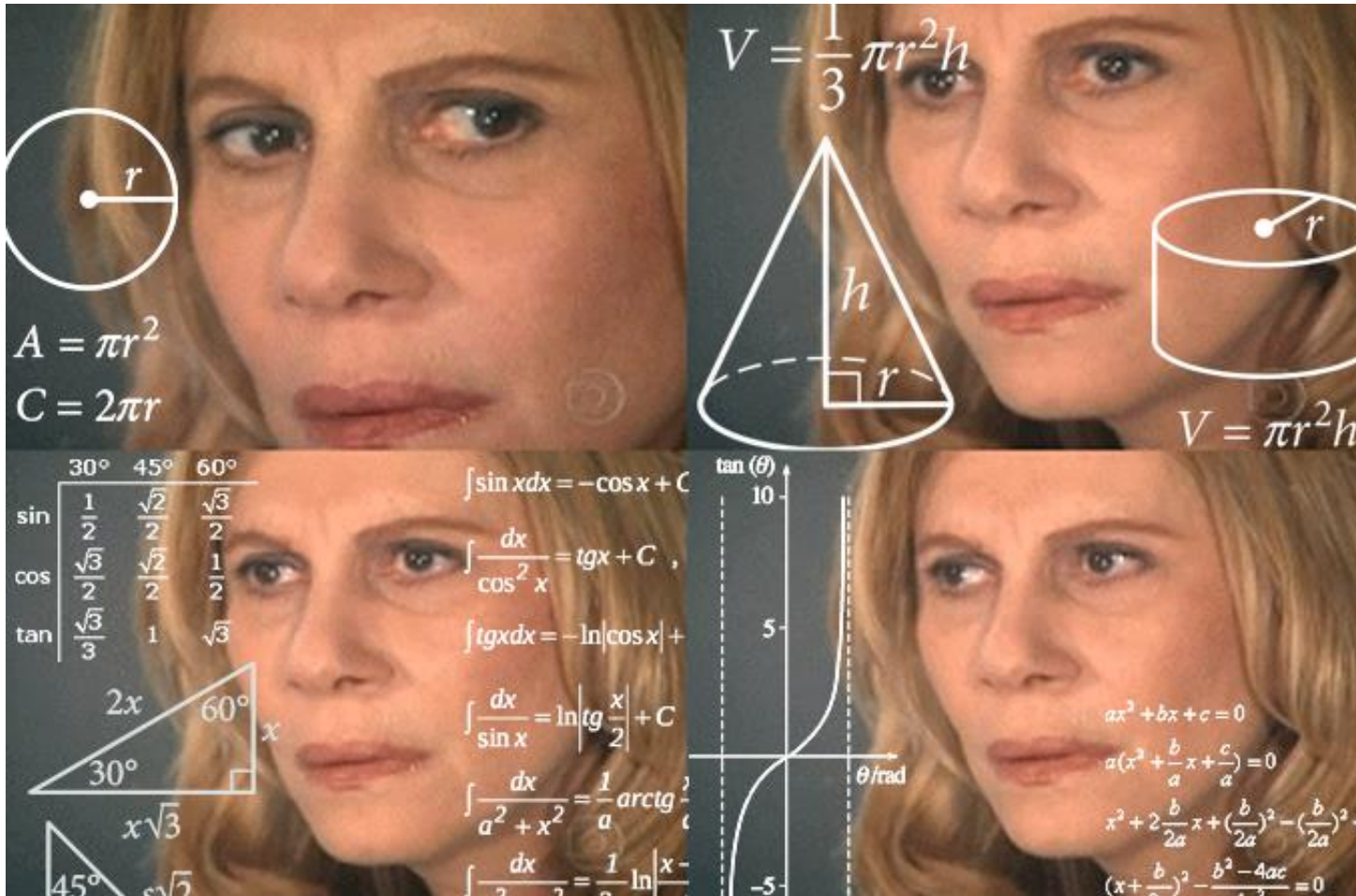




How do people in non-industrial societies learn to make tools?

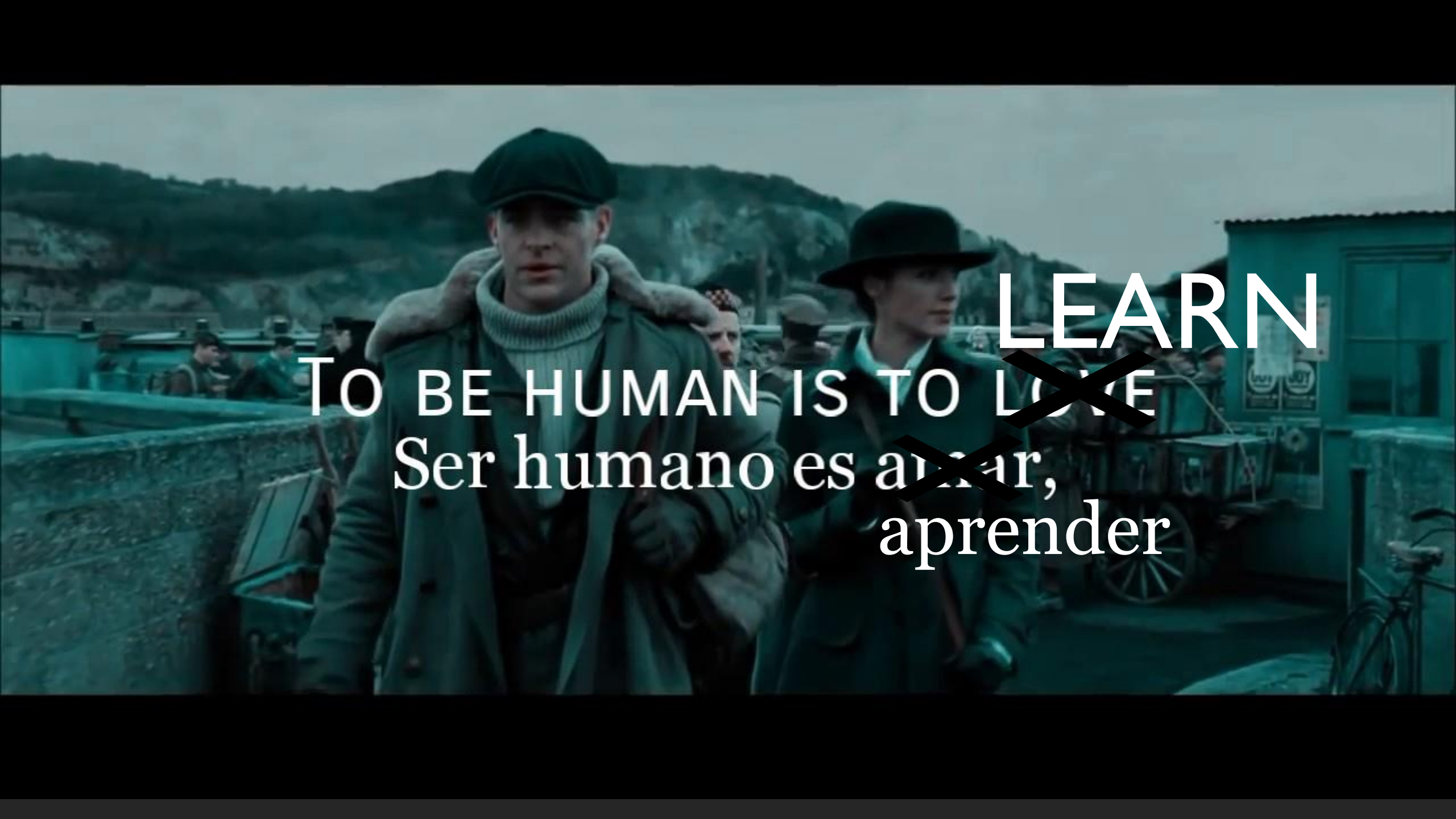
CHENG LIU

EMORY UNIVERSITY

HRAF 2022



TO BE HUMAN IS TO LOVE
Ser humano es amar,



LEARN

TO BE HUMAN IS TO LOVE

Ser humano es amar,
aprender

What has been done?

Hum Nat (2017) 28:367–394
DOI 10.1007/s12110-017-9302-2



How Do Hunter-Gatherer Children Learn Subsistence Skills?

A Meta-Ethnographic Review

Sheina Lew-Levy¹ · Rachel Reckin² · Noa Lavi³ ·
Jurgi Cristóbal-Azkarate⁴ · Kate Ellis-Davies^{1,5}

Published online: 9 October 2017

© The Author(s) 2017. This article is an open access publication

Abstract Hunting and gathering is, evolutionarily, the defining subsistence strategy of our species. Studying how children learn foraging skills can, therefore, provide us with key data to test theories about the evolution of human life history, cognition, and social behavior. Modern foragers, with their vast cultural and environmental diversity, have mostly been studied individually. However, cross-cultural studies allow us to extrapolate forager-wide trends in how, when, and from whom hunter-gatherer children learn their subsistence skills. We perform a meta-ethnography, which allows us to systematically extract, summarize, and compare both quantitative and qualitative literature. We found 58 publications focusing on learning subsistence skills. Learning begins early in infancy, when parents take children on foraging expeditions and give them toy versions of tools. In early and middle childhood, children transition into the multi-age playgroup, where they learn skills through play, observation, and participation. By the end of middle childhood, most children are proficient food collectors. However, it is not until adolescence that adults (not necessarily parents) begin directly teaching children complex skills such as hunting and complex tool manufacture. Adolescents seek to learn innovations from adults,

Lew-Levy et al., 2017

A Cross-Cultural Analysis of Hunter-Gatherer Social Learning

2

Zachary H. Garfield, Melissa J. Garfield, and Barry S. Hewlett

Abstract

Social learning among hunter-gatherers has been widely discussed in the literature and authors often draw on ethnographic cases to support theoretical models. In this study we report on the cross-cultural occurrence of various modes and processes of social learning in distinct cultural domains from the ethnographic record. To our knowledge this is the first systematic, cross-cultural study of hunter-gatherer social learning. We rely on the sample of hunter-gatherers in the electronic Human Relations Area Files (eHRAF) to generate our source of ethnographic texts. We have coded and analyzed 982 ethnographic texts from 23 diverse societies. Oblique and vertical transmission appear at similar rates. Various forms of teaching are the most common process of social learning and account for more than half of all coded texts. Vertical and oblique social learning are predominantly characterized by teaching, whereas horizontal social learning is primarily through collaborative learning. Approximations of age reveal a general developmental pattern in which social learning of miscellaneous skills characterizes infancy, subsistence skills dominate early and middle childhood, and the social learning of religious beliefs are most frequent during adolescence. Across development we identify a reduction in the importance of vertical transmission in favor of oblique transmission, for subsistence skills in particular. These results highlight the importance of teaching in the ethnographic record of hunter-gatherer social learning and provide a systematic, cross-cultural, framework for theoretical models to rely on.

Garfield et al., 2016

**HOW CAN YOU REALLY
KNOW SOMETHING**

**IF YOU HAVEN'T PUT IT
IN YOUR MOUTH?**

Why even
bother?

Research questions

1. Do hunter-gatherers have a unique learning pattern compared with groups practicing other types of subsistence strategies?
2. Do learning strategies change across different developmental periods?
3. What are some major transmission biases involved?

Searching strategies

OCM 869: Transmission of skills

+

Keywords: ~~tool~~, make, produce, ~~create~~, ~~construct~~, manufacture, assemble, form, fabricate, shape, ~~forge~~, etc.



Coding scheme



Who?



Where?



When?



How?

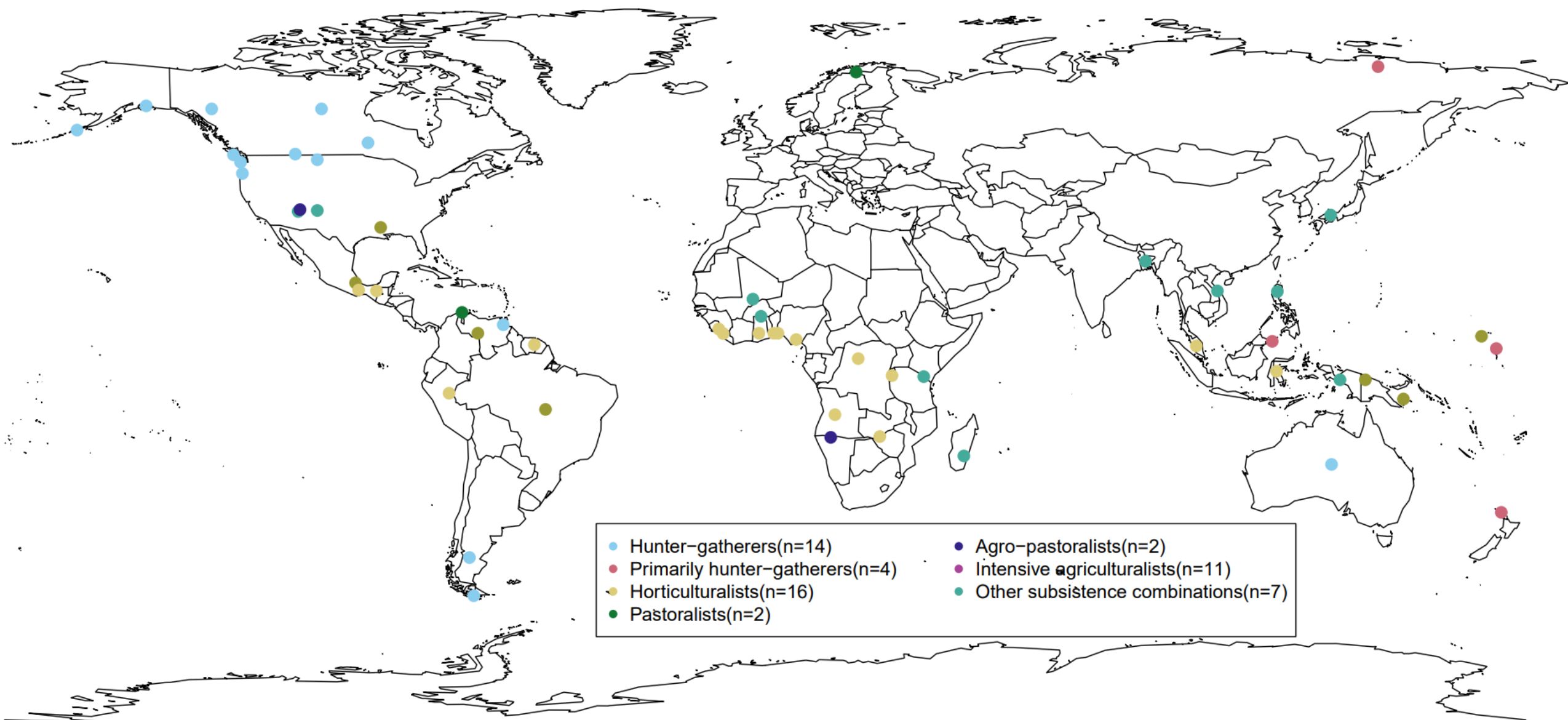


What?

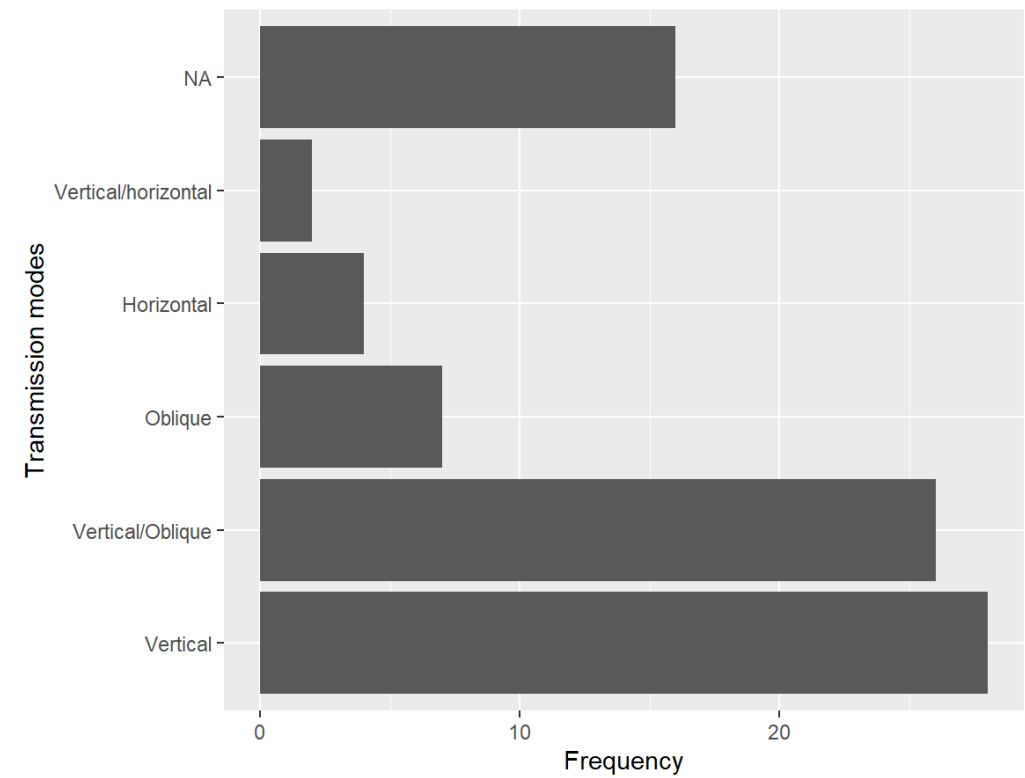
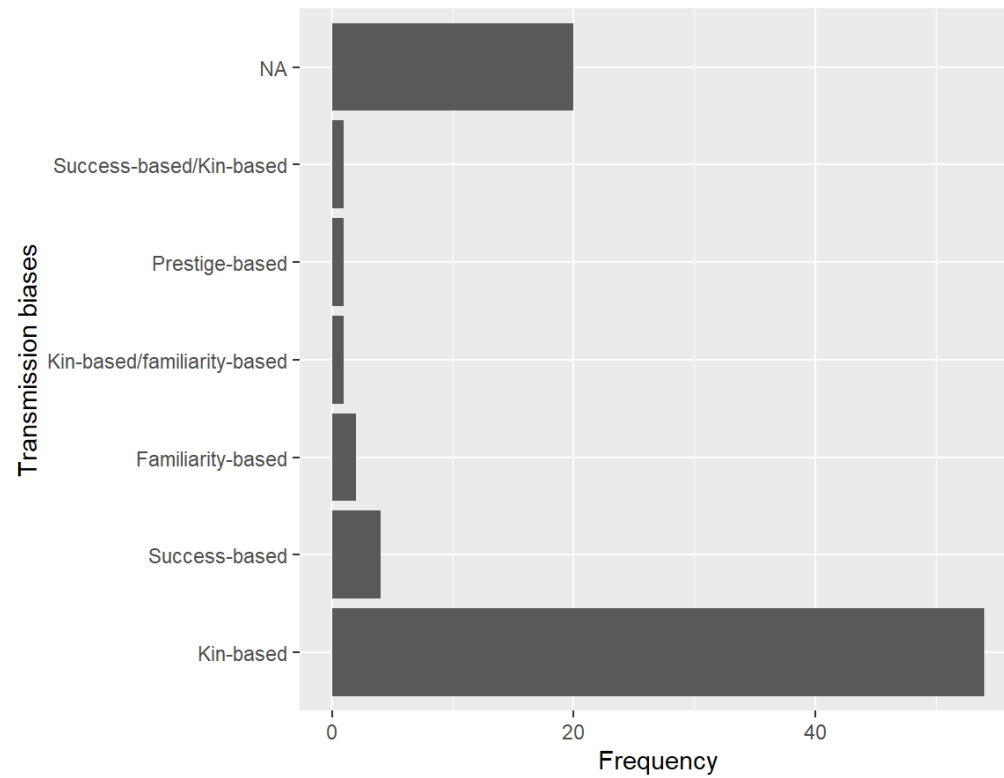


Why?

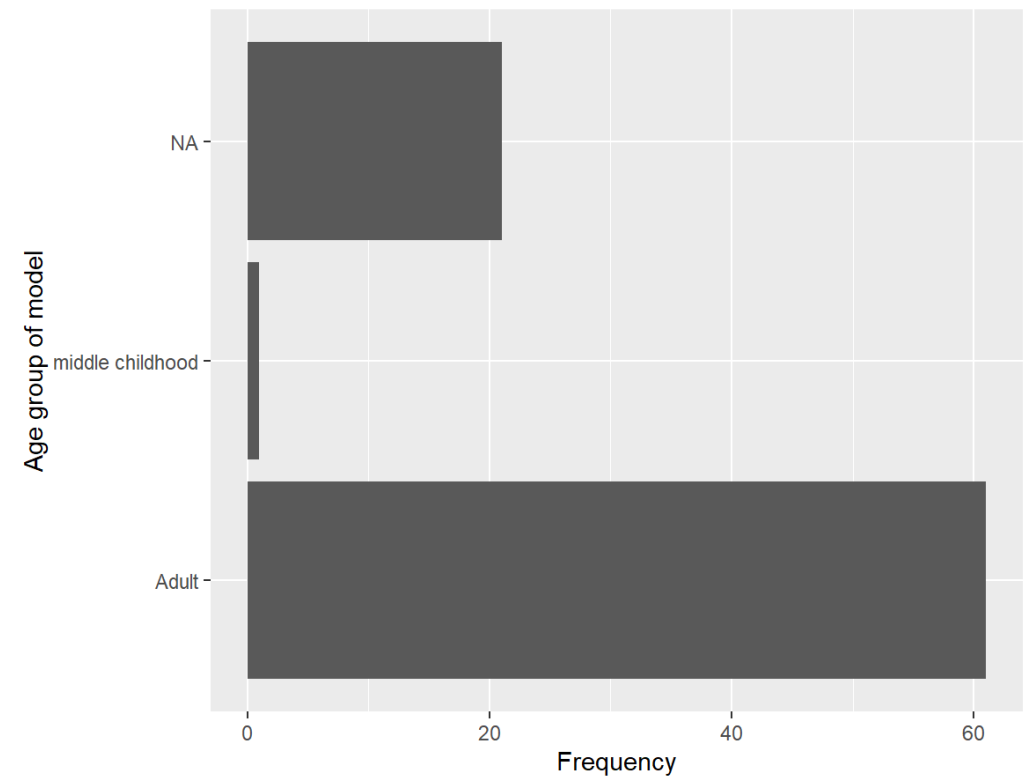
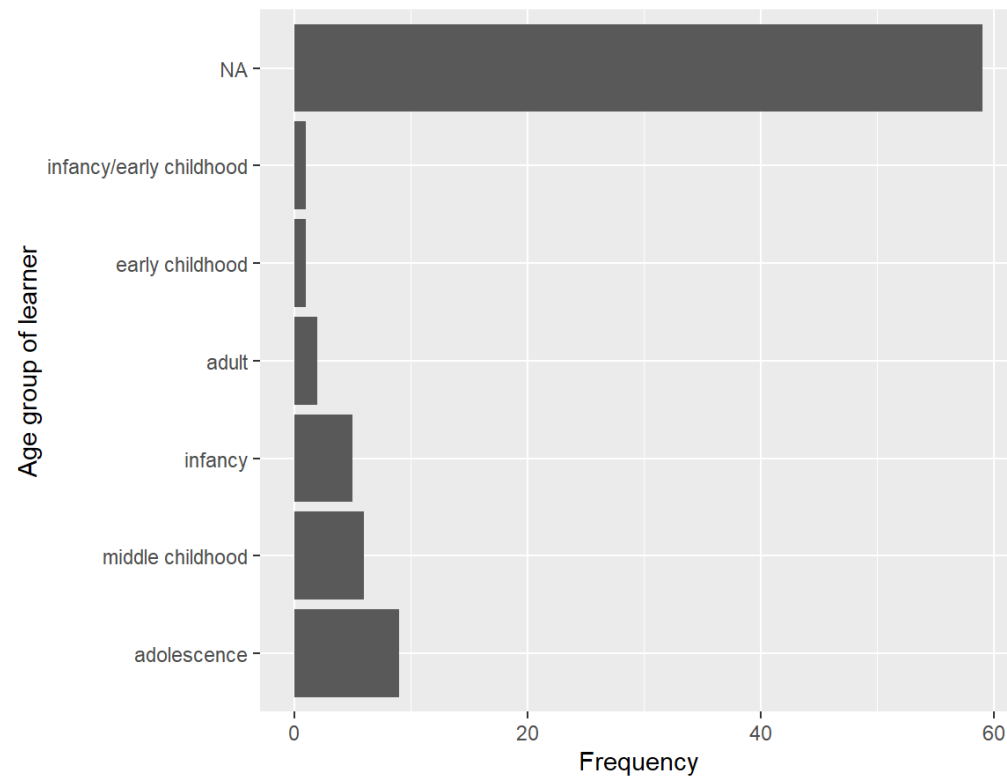
,



What have I done so far?



What have I done so far?



Descriptive research is valuable!



Sheina Lew-Levy

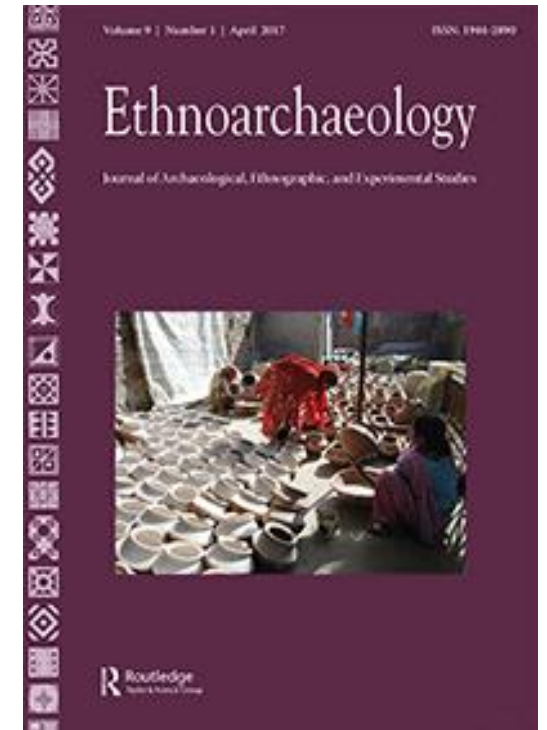
Max Planck Institute for Evolutionary Anthropology.

Verified email at eva.mpg.de - [Homepage](#)

cross-cultural psychology hunter-gatherer children social learning

FOLLOW

TITLE	CITED BY	YEAR
How Do Hunter-Gatherer Children Learn Subsistence Skills? A meta-ethnographic review S Lew-Levy, R Reckin, N Lavi, J Cristóbal-Azkarate, K Ellis-Davies Human Nature 28 (4), 367-394 98 5 101 0	126	2017
Universal norm psychology leads to societal diversity in prosocial behaviour and development BR House, P Kanngiesser, HC Barrett, T Broesch, S Cebiglu, ... Nature Human Behaviour 4 (1), 36-44 68 1 82 1	78	2020
How do hunter-gatherer children learn social and gender norms? A meta-ethnographic review S Lew-Levy, N Lavi, R Reckin, J Cristóbal-Azkarate, K Ellis-Davies Cross-Cultural Research 52 (2), 213-255 63 2 39 0	69	2018



This work was assisted in part by skills learned at the 2022 NSF HRAF Summer Institute for Cross Cultural Anthropological Research (NSF BCS Grant #2020156 to HRAF).



You are the best!

Credit: Seán Roberts